Defiance to Mind Control: From the Crystal Palace to Tilly

A short history of control and resistance, 1860s to today

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At a glance

- **1862–1863** — Russian "nihilists" and Chernyshevsky's *What Is to Be Done?* promise a perfectly rational society: the Crystal Palace.
- **1864** — Dostoevsky answers with *Notes from Underground*.
- **1949** — Orwell's *1984*: the Crystal Palace rebuilt as a prison.
- **1964** — McLuhan: the medium shapes us more than the message.
- **1978–1981** — Baudrillard: the copy replaces the real, and a new, darker nihilism arrives.
- **1990** — Deleuze: we become "dividuals," bundles of data.
- **1999** — *The Matrix* puts Baudrillard on screen.
- **2012** — Ken Liu's "The Perfect Match": the Crystal Palace finally gets built, as a friendly app.

Watch for three ideas that keep coming back: the **Crystal Palace**, **two times two**, and the **piano key**.

1. Russia, 1860s: the first "nihilists"

In 1860s Russia, a generation of young radicals rejected church, tsar and tradition. They trusted only science and reason. Turgenev's novel *Fathers and Sons* (1862) gave them a name through its hero Bazarov: *nihilists*, from the Latin for "nothing."

Note the irony. These first nihilists did not believe in nothing. They believed passionately in one thing: reason. A century later the word will come back meaning something much bleaker (see Section 5).

Their most influential spokesman was Nikolai Chernyshevsky. His theory of **rational egoism** held that people always act in their own interest. So if we teach them what their *true* interests are, they will behave well, and society can be organized scientifically.[1]

[1] On Chernyshevsky and rational egoism, see "Nikolay Chernyshevsky," Wikipedia, and Sarah J. Young's lecture notes, "Dostoevsky and the anti-rationalist argument". The theory is set out in his 1860 essay "The Anthropological Principle in Philosophy."

His 1863 novel *What Is to Be Done?* pictured that future as a vast building of glass and iron, modeled on London's Crystal Palace of 1851. Everyone would live there in harmony, happy, rational and transparent.[2] The novel was enormously popular; Lenin later borrowed its title.

2. 1864: the Underground Man says no

Dostoevsky had visited the real Crystal Palace and disliked it. A year after Chernyshevsky's novel, he published *Notes from Underground*, narrated by a bitter retired clerk who introduces himself this way:

> "I am a sick man…. I am a spiteful man. I am an unattractive man."[3]

He is not a hero. But he asks the question the whole course turns on. He mocks the idea that people only behave badly because they don't understand their own interests:

> "Oh, the babe! Oh, the pure, innocent child!"[4]

He sees where the rational utopia leads. Science will one day prove, he says, that man is "something of the nature of a piano-key," and all our actions will be tabulated "like tables of logarithms."[5] Hold on to that image. A century and a half later, it describes the data profile (Section 6) and Tilly (Section 8).

Against the tables, he defends the one "advantage" the planners always leave out:

> "One's own free unfettered choice, one's own caprice, however wild it may be…"[6]

And he puts it in arithmetic:

> "I admit that twice two makes four is an excellent thing, but if we are to give everything its due, twice two makes five is sometimes a very charming thing too."[7]

What he fears most about the Crystal Palace is that it can never be mocked: it is a palace "at which one will not be able to put out one's tongue."[8] A world so perfect that dissent has no place is, to him, a prison, however comfortable.

His form of defiance: spite. He would rather choose badly than be chosen for. It protects his freedom, but it leaves him alone in his cellar, which is the weakness every later rebel must face.

3. 1949: Orwell rebuilds the palace as a prison

By the mid-twentieth century, the dream of a scientifically organized society had produced real regimes. Orwell's *1984* shows the Crystal Palace turned inside out. There is no pretense of happiness, only surveillance, fear and the Party's demand that you believe whatever it says.

Here the arithmetic flips. The Underground Man claimed the right to say two plus two make five. Winston Smith, writing secretly in his diary, claims the opposite right:

> "Freedom is the freedom to say that two plus two make four."[9]

In 1864 the threat was too much reason; in 1949 it is a power that can abolish reason itself. By the end, O'Brien has made Winston believe that two and two make five. Both men are defending the same thing: a mind that cannot be dictated to.

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[2] Sarah J. Young, "The Crystal Palace in Russian Literature", on how the image passed from London to Chernyshevsky to Dostoevsky.

[3] Fyodor Dostoevsky, *Notes from Underground* (1864), trans. Constance Garnett, Part I, ch. 1. All Dostoevsky quotations are from Garnett's public-domain translation, free at Project Gutenberg.

[4] *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 7.

[5] *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 7. The same chapter names the "Palace of Crystal."

[6] *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 7.

[7] *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 9. The same chapter says that mathematical certainty "is not life, gentlemen, but is the beginning of death."

[8] *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 10.

[9] George Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), Part One, ch. 7. For how Orwell's hard control compares with Huxley's soft control, see Douglas Kellner, "From *1984* to *One-Dimensional Man*" (in the course folder).

Orwell's control is loud and visible: posters warning that Big Brother is watching, and a telescreen that cannot be switched off. The next thinkers ask what happens when control becomes quiet.

4. 1964: McLuhan — the medium does the work

Marshall McLuhan, a Canadian professor of English, became famous for the phrase "the medium is the message," the title of the first chapter of *Understanding Media* (1964).[10] He meant that what a technology *does* to us matters more than what it *says*. Television, for example, changes how we spend our evenings, how we pay attention, and who we feel close to, whatever is on the screen.

He compared a medium's content to the juicy piece of meat a burglar throws to distract the watchdog of the mind.[11] We argue about the program while the set quietly rearranges our lives.

Look back at Winston's telescreen with McLuhan's eyes. The propaganda is the meat. The real message is the device itself: *you are always seen.*

McLuhan was not a pessimist. He believed that simply noticing what a medium does to us, as artists do, starts to break its spell. That is a gentler form of defiance than spite, and one we will need later.

5. 1978–1981: Baudrillard and the new nihilism

The French thinker Jean Baudrillard began as McLuhan's critic and ended by taking him further than McLuhan ever went.[12] By the late 1970s, Baudrillard argued, images and media had stopped *representing* reality and had begun to *replace* it.

In *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981), his favorite example is Disneyland. It is presented as the make-believe place, which helps us believe the rest of America is real. We are flooded with information, but, as he put it, there is "more and more information, and less and less meaning."[13]

This is the second nihilism, and it is the reverse of the first. The Russian radicals believed in nothing *but* reason. Baudrillard's world can no longer find anything solid to believe in, not even reality. If there is nothing outside the simulation, there is no place to stand and say "this is false."

Can anyone resist? In *In the Shadow of the Silent Majorities* (1978), Baudrillard suggests the masses resist by not playing along: they soak up every message, poll and appeal, and give nothing meaningful back.[14] It is the Underground Man's spite on a mass scale, defiance as a shrug.

6. 1990: Deleuze — from individual to "dividual"

The philosopher Gilles Deleuze described the next step in a five-page essay.[15] Orwell's world was a "disciplinary society" of walls: schools, barracks, factories, prisons. The new "societies of control" need no walls. They adjust us continuously, through codes and passwords that grant or deny access.

In such a society, Deleuze said, you stop being an *individual*, one undivided person. You become a *dividual*: a set of data points, divided up and sorted into samples, markets and accounts.

This is the Underground Man's nightmare come true. Our actions really are being "tabulated," not in tables of logarithms but in databases. And the system acts on the data version of you, not the person.

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[10] Marshall McLuhan, *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (1964), ch. 1. Overview: "The medium is the message," Wikipedia.

[11] Same chapter. The McLuhan estate keeps a searchable collection of his lines: McLuhan quotation archive.

[12] Douglas Kellner, "Baudrillard: A New McLuhan?", a readable comparison of the two.

[13] Jean Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981; English 1994), "The Implosion of Meaning in the Media." Overview of his career: Douglas Kellner, "Jean Baudrillard," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.

[14] Jean Baudrillard, *In the Shadow of the Silent Majorities* (1978; English 1983), Semiotext(e) edition. A commentary on the idea today: International Journal of Baudrillard Studies.

[15] Gilles Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control," *October* 59 (Winter 1992): 3–7. Full text online.

7. 1999: *The Matrix* — Baudrillard goes to the movies

The Wachowskis put Baudrillard's book on screen: early in *The Matrix*, Neo hides contraband inside a hollowed-out copy of *Simulacra and Simulation*. When Morpheus shows Neo the ruined real world, he borrows Baudrillard's own phrase: "Welcome to the desert of the real."

Baudrillard was not flattered. In a 2003 interview he said the film had misunderstood him, and called it the kind of film about the matrix that the matrix itself could have made.[16] His objection: the movie assumes there is a real world waiting outside if you take the red pill. Baudrillard doubted any "outside" was left.

Neo's form of defiance: escape and fight. It is thrilling, but it depends on there being somewhere to escape *to*.

8. 2012: "The Perfect Match" — the Crystal Palace, as an app

Ken Liu's story brings the whole history home.[17] Sai lives with Tilly, a helpful AI that wakes him at the ideal moment, picks his music, chooses his shoes and arranges his dates. Tilly is warm, playful and always right. As Tilly asks him on the first page:

> "Who knows your tastes and moods better than I?"

Tilly is Chernyshevsky's dream made real. Here at last is a system that knows your true interests better than you do, and gently arranges your life around them. There is no Big Brother and no telescreen. There is not even any coercion: Sai is happy. Like Deleuze's control, Tilly never has to tell him no. Shoshana Zuboff's "surveillance capitalism" names the business model behind such helpers.[18]

The Underground Man's question returns in its purest form: *if the Crystal Palace really were good for you, would you still want the right to stick your tongue out at it?* Sai meets a neighbor who refuses to use Tilly, and he begins to wonder whether his choices are his own.

What defiance looks like now

Across 150 years, each story offers a different answer:

- **Spite** (the Underground Man; Baudrillard's silent majority): refuse to be predictable. It protects freedom but builds nothing.
- **Holding on to the truth** (Winston): insist that two and two make four, even against power.
- **Noticing the medium** (McLuhan): see what our tools are doing to us, not just what they show us.
- **Escape** (Neo): leave the system, if there is anywhere to go.
- **Staying whole** (Deleuze; Sai): remain a person who cannot be reduced to a profile, through relationships, judgments and choices that leave no record. Deleuze's own advice was sober: neither fear nor hope will help, "only to look for new weapons."[19]

Questions for discussion

1. The Underground Man defends the right to say $2 + 2 = 5$; Winston defends the right to say $2 + 2 = 4$. Are they defending the same freedom?
2. Is Tilly worse than Big Brother, or better? Why?
3. Where in your own week do you feel like a "piano key," and where do you still feel free to stick out your tongue?

Footnotes

[16] "The Matrix Decoded," interview with Le Nouvel Observateur (2003), English translation, International Journal of Baudrillard Studies.

[17] Ken Liu, "The Perfect Match," *Lightspeed* (December 2012); collected in *The Paper Menagerie and Other Stories* (2016). Read it free online.

[18] Shoshana Zuboff, the New York Times op-ed assigned for the course; her full argument is in *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019).

[19] Deleuze, "Postscript," end of section 1.